USDA Rural Development — Centralized Training Conference Site & Budget Approval Brief

Prepared by: Conference Coordinator, USDA Rural Development | Date of analysis: 2026-10-24 | Training dates: Nov 29 – Dec 1, 2026

1. Recommendation

Recommended option: BOSTON, MA — 24 attendees.

- Estimated grand total: $34,242.77 (base $32,612.16 + 5% contingency reserve $1,630.61) — $18,757 under the $53,000 ceiling.
- Flights: DCA ⇄ BOS, American nonstop, ~$358 round trip (ITA Matrix, 2026-10-24).
- Lodging: DoubleTree by Hilton Boston Bayside — $108/night, guest rating 8.6/10 (449 reviews, Trip.com 2026-10-24), breakfast included, free airport shuttle; 4 nights (Nov 28–Dec 2) at/below the FY2027 $213 Boston lodging cap on every night.
- Why 24 (not 18): the ceiling is met with large margin, so the decision rule prioritizes the larger group; 24-person total is lowest among all cities that fit.

2. How the recommendation was chosen

Candidates: Chicago (ORD), Denver (DEN), Phoenix (PHX), Boston (BOS), Seattle (SEA). All five were priced with real flight quotes (ITA Matrix) and ≥2 real hotel quotes per city (Trip.com), screened for a quality standard (guest rating ≥8.0/10, ≥50 reviews, breakfast included/budgeted) and per-diem lodging-cap compliance (41 CFR 301-11.100 / 301-74.6).

Decision rule (applied in order): fit the $53,000 ceiling → maximize attendees → lowest total-with-reserve → alphabetical.

24-person totals (incl. 5% reserve):

- Boston $34,242.77 ← recommended (lowest)
- Chicago $39,528.72 ← nearest competitive alternative
- Denver $45,519.26 | Phoenix $45,687.60 | Seattle $50,789.09

All five cities fit the ceiling at 24 attendees in the base case. Boston wins because its compliant breakfast-included hotel ($108) plus free airport shuttle more than offset its higher airfare vs. Chicago.

3. Key amounts (recommended Boston · 24)

Line	Amount (USD)
Airfare (24 × $358)	8,592.00
Lodging room (24 × $108 × 4 nights)	10,368.00
Lodging tax (internal 12% est.)	1,244.16
Registration (24 × $180)	4,320.00
Agency meals (2 dinners + Dec-2 lunch, 24)	2,400.00
Light refreshments (24 × $15 × 3 days)	1,080.00
Ground transport (home↔DCA; airport shuttle free)	960.00
Meeting venue (3 days × $1,200, to be quoted)	3,600.00

Base subtotal	**32,612.16**
Contingency reserve (5%)	1,630.61
GRAND TOTAL	**34,242.77**
Budget ceiling	53,000.00
Headroom for unquoted/TBD base costs (ex-reserve)	17,864.03

4. Itinerary basis

- Arrive Nov 28 (day before); depart Dec 2 (day after) — fully covers training Nov 29–Dec 1.
- Hotel check-in Nov 28 / checkout Dec 2 = 4 nights. Flights, check-in/out, airport↔hotel transfer and venue dates all connect (see workbook 'Itinerary').
- Cheapest fares may be Basic Economy; a changeable fare is advised. The +20% airfare stress band absorbs this.

5. Flight-increase & switching conditions

- Airfare 0% → +20%: KEEP Boston 24. At +20% the total is $36,047.09 — still ~$16,953 under ceiling. No switch within the required band.
- Breakeven: Boston 24 would reach the ceiling only near +208% airfare — not a realistic trigger. So the recommendation does not switch to 18 people or another city on airfare alone in the 0–20% range.
- Only Seattle fails at +20% (24-person $55,713 > ceiling); the other four still fit.
- If Boston becomes unavailable, switch to Chicago 24 ($39,528.72 base case); note Chicago's $145 hotel is compliant only under FY2027 caps (would breach FY25/26 Dec-1 $142 cap).

6. Unquoted-cost sensitivity

The venue ($3,600) and ground transport are estimates to be quoted. Boston 24 can absorb up to $17,864 of additional base cost before touching the ceiling (reserve preserved); $16,146 after a +20% airfare shock. Recommendation holds as long as unquoted base costs stay within that headroom. It would be overturned only if combined unquoted overruns exceed ~$17.9k (base) — at which point step to Boston 18 (total ≈ $26,627) before changing city.

7. Historical per-diem contrast (FY2025/26/27)

- Applicable year is FY2027 (travel in FY2027, eff. Oct 1 2026). FY25/26 shown for contrast only — not for this reimbursement.
- Boston's $108 room is compliant under all three FY lodging caps — robust to rate-year.
- Lodging caps rose slightly FY25→FY27; M&IE unchanged. Event dollar totals are unchanged by FY (quotes held constant); only compliance/benchmarks move. Chicago's $145 room is non-compliant under FY25/26 Dec-1 caps.

8. Conditions before approval (see approval_register.csv)

- Venue address & 24-seat capacity not yet confirmed (Location Cost Estimate) — execution condition.

- Hotel 24-room block at quoted rate not confirmed; single-occupancy quote used as whole-group estimate only.
- Flight group inventory at quoted fare not guaranteed; FEMA fire-safe accommodation status to be verified.
- Funds availability, attendee roster/justification, and exact RD Instruction 2036-A clauses to be confirmed. Hotel/venue vendor eligibility, procurement and funding not yet verified.

9. Status of estimates

Known/quoted: flights, hotel nightly rates, registration, per-diem caps. Estimated: agency meals (GSA M&IE components), light refreshments, ground transport, internal 12% lodging tax. To be quoted: meeting venue, group room block, final catering. No quotes, inventory, bookings, credentials or approvals are fabricated; page-absent details are listed as to-verify.

Snapshot notice: This brief reflects the itinerary and parameters in conference_budget.xlsx as of 2026-10-24. If parameters or dates change, re-check quote applicability in the workbook and re-export this brief.